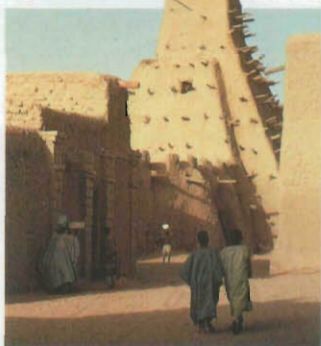


Mali

Desert and semi-desert cover the northern two-thirds of Mali, and only two per cent of the land can be cultivated. Most people live in the south, in farming settlements close to the rivers Niger and Senegal. Droughts, poor food, and an average life expectancy of only 51 years, make Mali one of the world's poorest countries. Some gold is mined, but cotton is the biggest export.

Buildings such as this granary are made from sand bricks.



MALI FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Bamako
AREA	1,220,190 sq km (471,115 sq miles)
POPULATION	11,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Bambara, Mande, Arabic, Fulani, Senufo, Soninke
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, traditional beliefs
CURRENCY	CFA franc



Making "mud cloth"

People

Mali's main peoples are the Bambara, Fulani, Tuareg, and Dogon, with smaller numbers of Songhai and Bozo. Bozo artists, mostly women, are noted for their "mud cloth", made by painting abstract designs on to rough cloth using differently coloured soils.

Tombouctou

Lying on the edge of the desert, Tombouctou is a city of sand still visited by camel caravans carrying salt from mines in the north for shipping up the River Niger to Mopti. This historic city is a centre of Islamic learning.

Burkina

Land-locked in the arid Sahel region and threatened by the Sahara, which is expanding southwards, Burkina (formerly Upper Volta) is one of West Africa's poorest and most overpopulated countries. Faced with droughts and lack of work, many young people are forced to leave to find jobs abroad.

Fulani

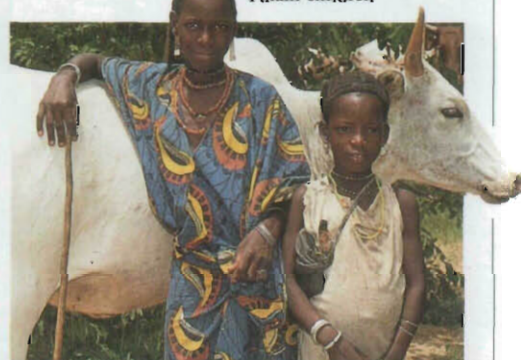
The Fulani are nomadic cattle herders who roam West Africa with their animals. In Burkina, where they number about 75,000, they are one of more than 60 ethnic groups. Fulani herders traditionally tend cattle for local farmers in exchange for sacks of rice.



BURKINA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Ouagadougou
AREA	273,800 sq km (105,714 sq miles)
POPULATION	11,600,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Mossi, Mande, Fulani, Lobi, Bobo
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Traditional beliefs, Muslim, Christian
CURRENCY	CFA franc

Fulani children



Cotton

Burkina's most valuable cash crop is cotton, which brings in about 25 per cent of its export earnings. However, the country's farming is threatened by the mass emigration of young workers, who send money home to their families. The country has deposits of silver and manganese, and exports gold.

Ghana

Once called the "Gold Coast" by Europeans who found gold here 500 years ago, Ghana still has reserves of gold, which has recently replaced cocoa as the country's major source of income. The country is still one of the world's largest cocoa producers. Lake Volta, formed by a dam on the River Volta, is the world's largest artificial lake.

GHANA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Accra
AREA	230,620 sq km (88,810 sq miles)
POPULATION	20,200,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	English, Akan, Mossi, Ewe, Ga, Twi, Fanti, Gurma
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, traditional beliefs, Muslim
CURRENCY	Cedi

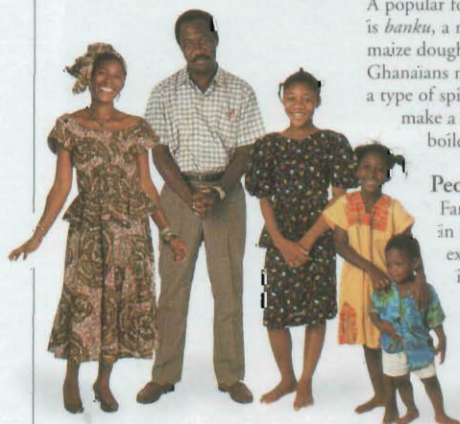


Food

A popular food in Ghana is *banku*, a mixture of maize dough and cassava. Ghanaians mix leaves of *eseye*, a type of spinach, with palm oil to make a sauce that is eaten with boiled fish or vegetables.

People

Family ties are strong in Ghana, and the extended family is important. About half of Ghanaians are Ashanti people whose ancestors developed one of the richest and most famous civilizations in Africa. Other groups include the Mole-Dagbani, Ewe, and Ga. About 38 per cent of the people live in cities and towns.



Ghanaian family

Togo

A long, narrow country, just 110 km (68 miles) at its widest point, Togo has a central forested plateau with savannah to the north and south. Nearly half the population is under 15 years of age, and few people are more than 45. Although most people are farmers, Togo's main export is phosphates, used for making fertilizers.

TOGO FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Lomé
AREA	54,390 sq km (21,000 sq miles)
POPULATION	4,600,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	French, Kabye, Ewe
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Traditional beliefs, Christian, Muslim
CURRENCY	CFA franc



Market women

Although politics and formal employment remain the domain of men, many Togolese women work informally in part-time jobs. The Nana Benz, wealthy women traders so-called because they all seem to own Mercedes Benz cars, dominate Togo's markets and taxi businesses. Based in the market at Lomé, these formidable women fight hard for business and have a legendary capacity for haggling.

Farming

Togolese farmers produce cocoa, coffee, cotton, copra, and palm kernels mainly for export. New products include herbs, tomatoes, and sugar. For their own use, they grow millet, cassava, and maize. Fishing is important in coastal areas.

Maize

